

CAN FACTS REALLY BE SEPARATED FROM VALUES?

A visual introduction to Hilary Putnam's fact-value entanglement

FACTS

"The temperature is 90°F"



VALUES

"Cruelty is bad"

The ordinary picture looks clean. Too clean.

The traditional dichotomy

The picture we are about to test.

F = FACTS

observation
measurement
empirical claims
theory

V = VALUES

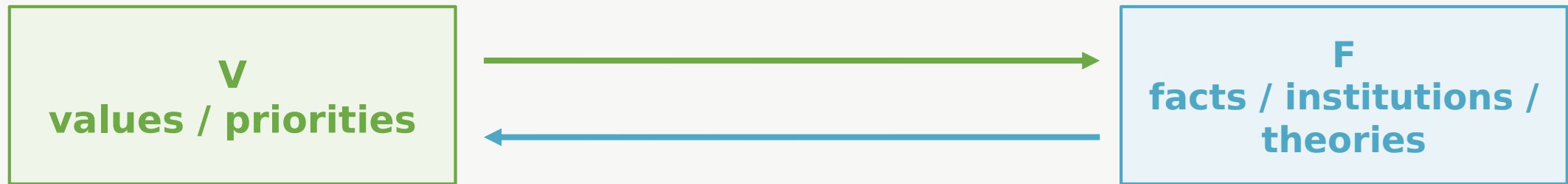
good / bad
right / wrong
rational / irrational
ought

$$F \cap V = \emptyset$$

The alleged boundary: description on one side, evaluation on the other.

The first crack: mutual influence

Even before Putnam, the clean wall starts leaking.



Values select what gets built, funded, measured, defended.

Facts and consequences reshape what people value next.

law

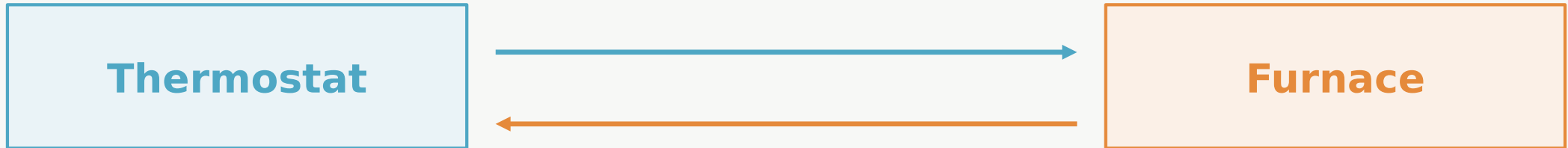
research
agenda

design choice

V → F and F → V: interaction is real. But interaction alone is not yet Putnam.

Interaction is not yet entanglement

A useful objection keeps us honest.



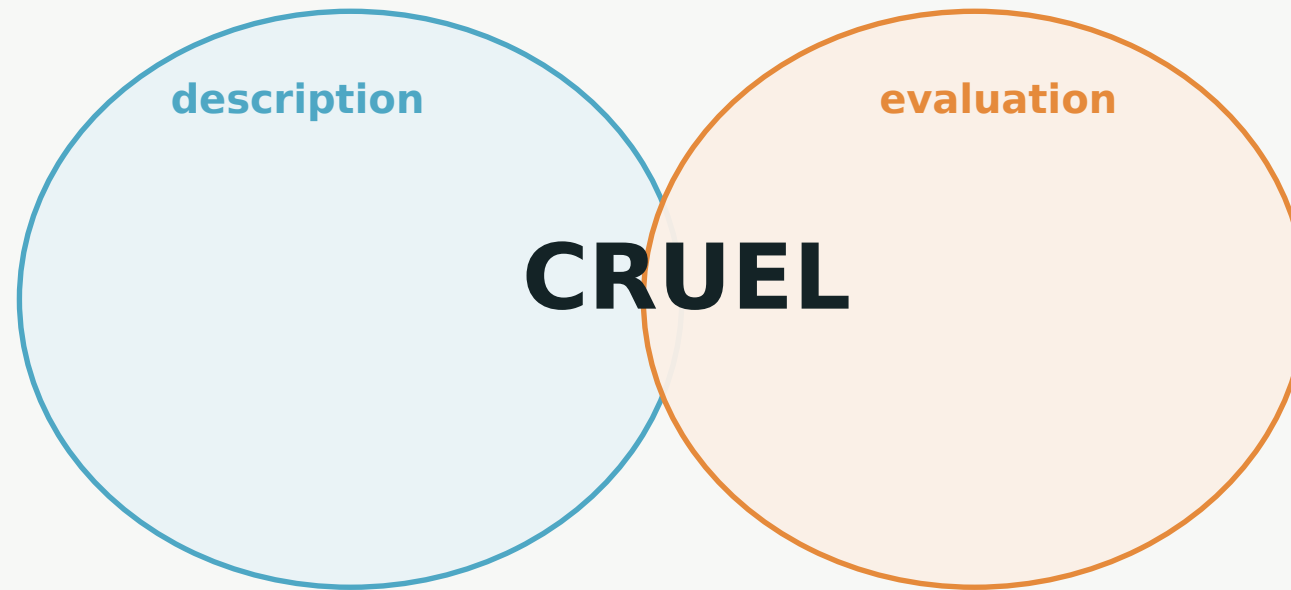
They interact.

They are not the same thing.

$V \rightarrow F$ and $F \rightarrow V \neq$ conceptual inseparability

Enter the thick concept

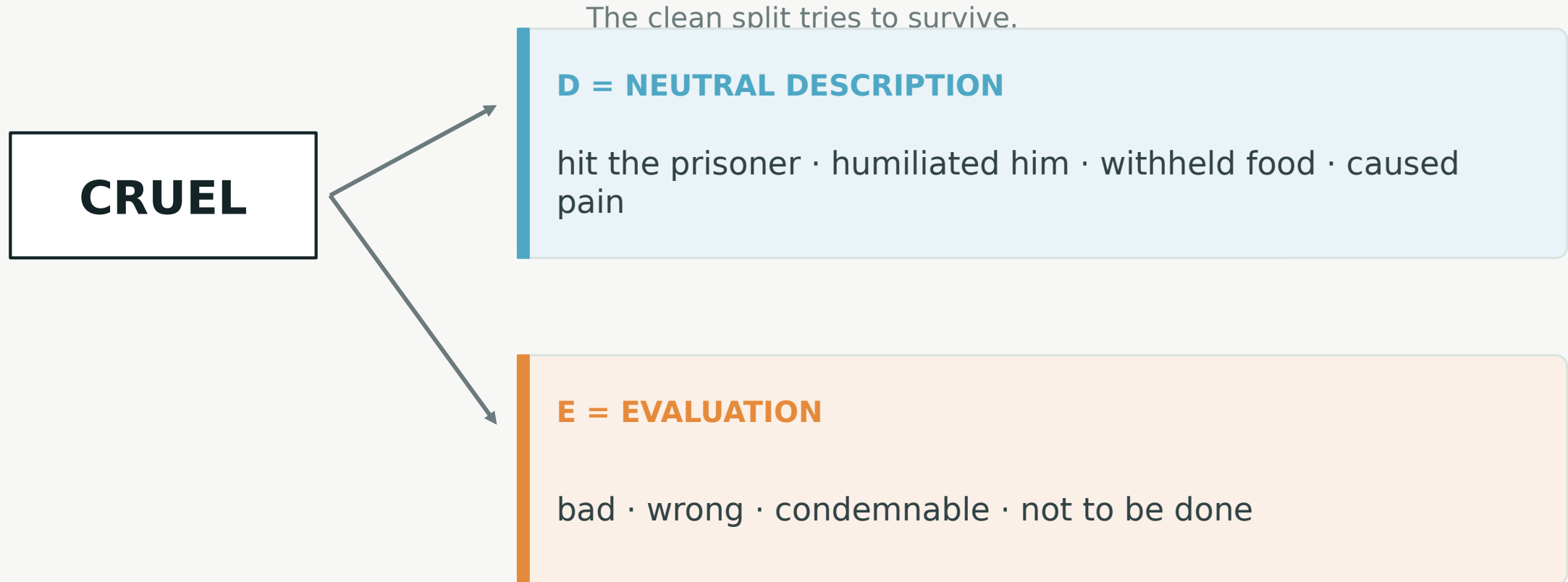
Putnam's pressure point is not causal. It is conceptual.



“The guard behaved cruelly toward the prisoner.”

A thick concept seems to say what happened and how to assess it.

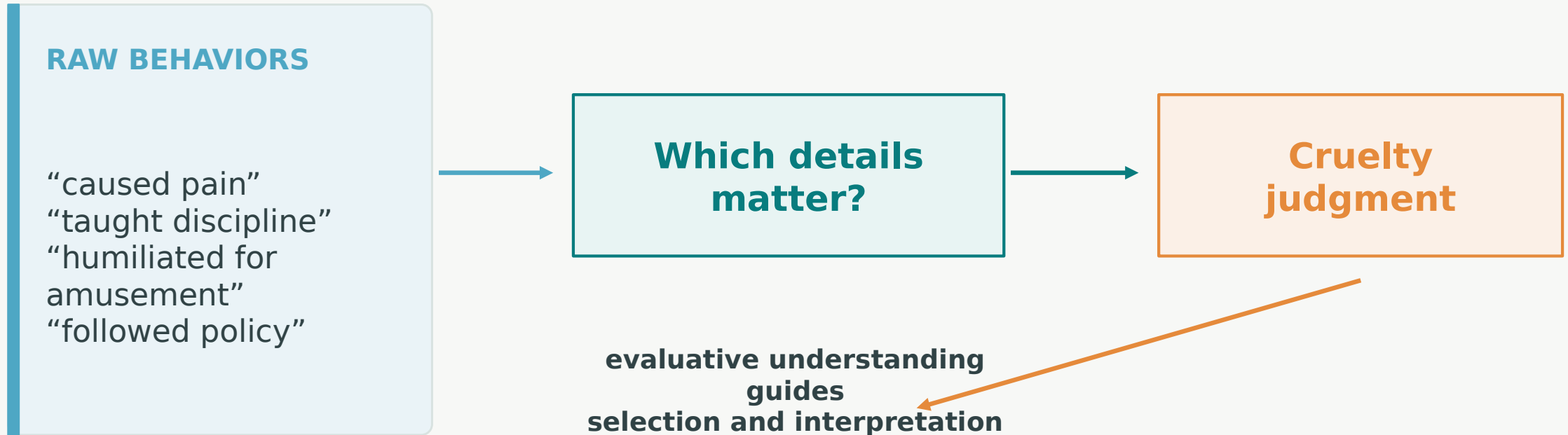
The tempting decomposition



Cruel = D + E ?

Putnam: not so fast

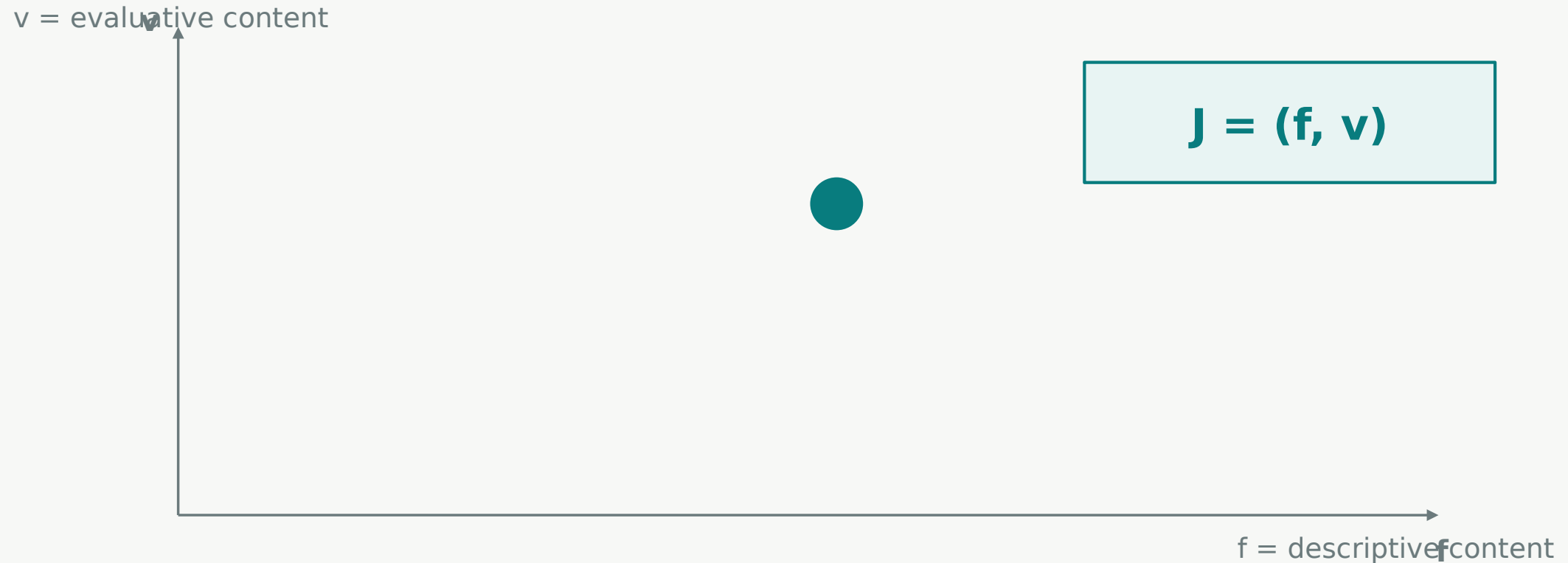
The value is not merely stapled on afterward.



To recognize the relevant facts as cruelty, you already need the evaluative concept.

A visual model of judgment

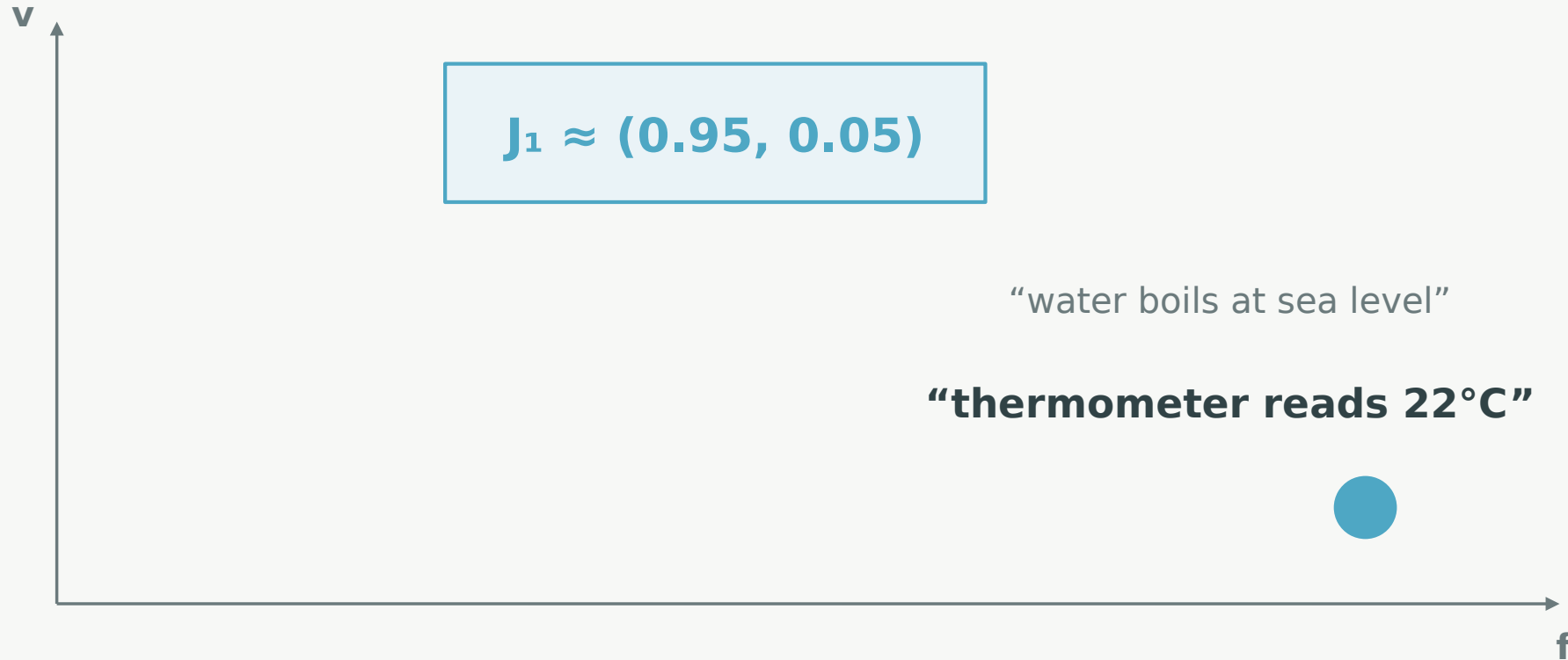
This is our map, not Putnam's math.



A judgment can have both descriptive and evaluative coordinates.

Some judgments lean descriptive

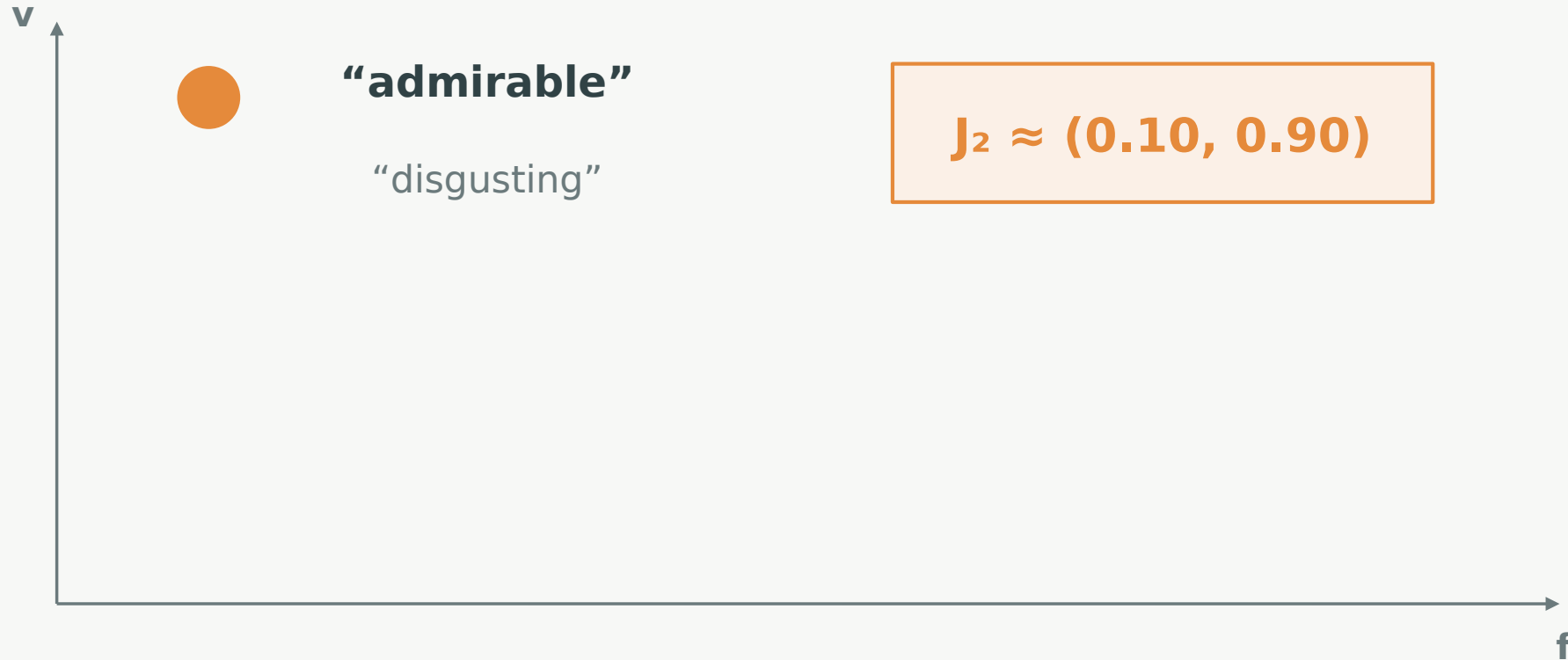
The model allows degrees.



Close to the descriptive axis does not mean literally value-free.

Some judgments lean evaluative

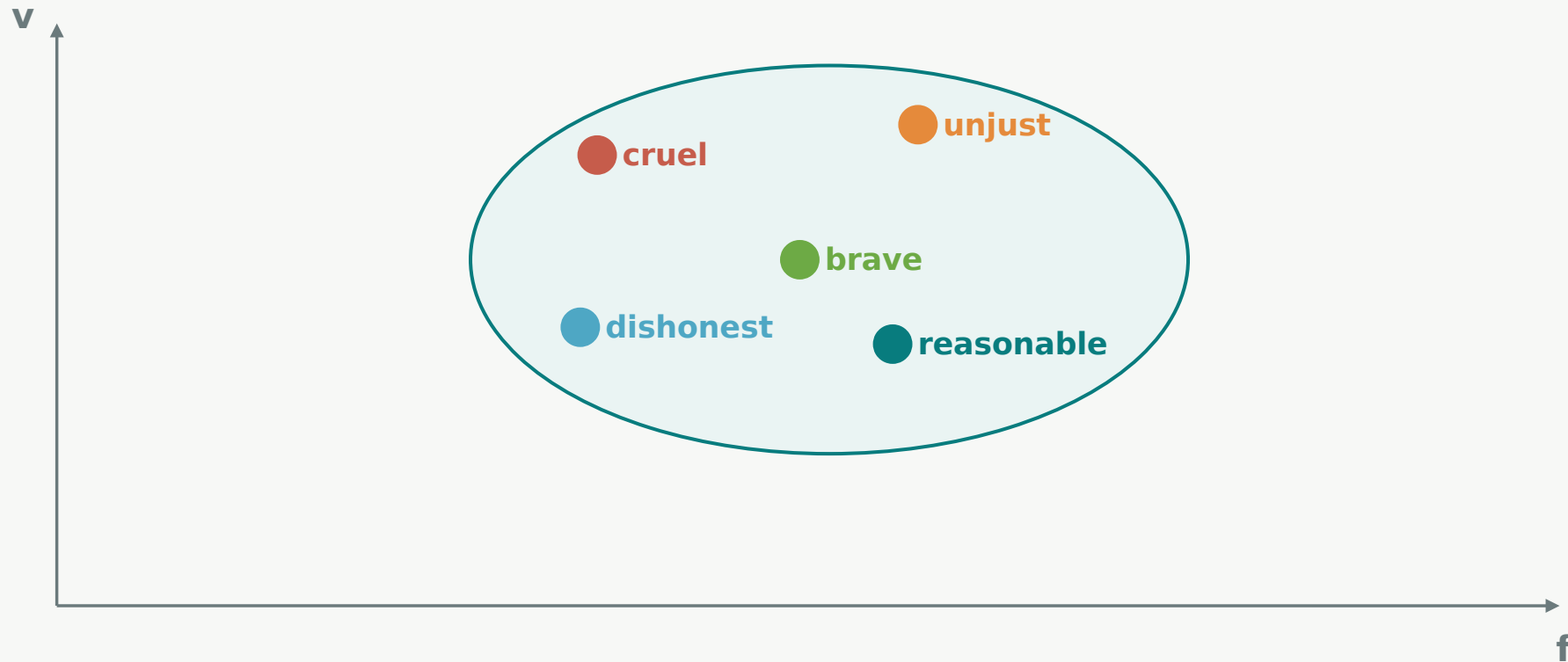
The other extreme also exists.



Some claims are overwhelmingly evaluative without being empty of description.

The thick region

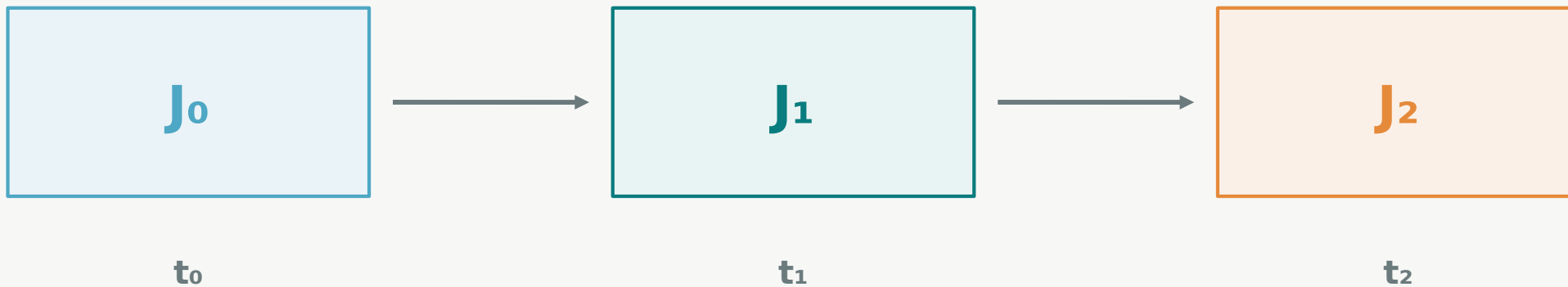
Much of human life sits in the middle.



Thick concepts occupy the zone where description and evaluation travel together.

Static entanglement is only the beginning

Now we let the picture move through time.



$$J_t = (f_t, v_t)$$

The judgment changes because both our factual situation and our evaluative orientation can change.

Values guide inquiry

Inquiry starts with standards, interests, and priorities.



What counts as important?

What counts as elegant?

What counts as explanation?

simplicity

evidence

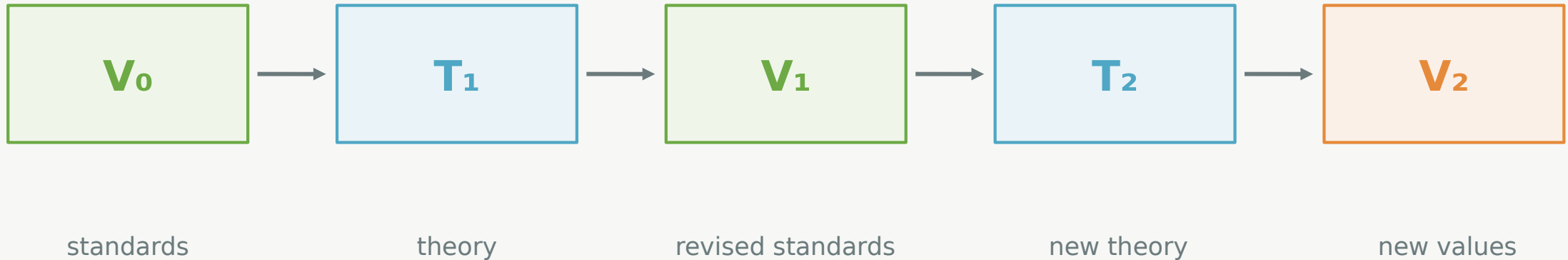
scope

fairness

Values do not dictate the answer. They help determine what counts as a question and a good answer.

Inquiry reshapes value

The return loop is where the machine gets interesting.

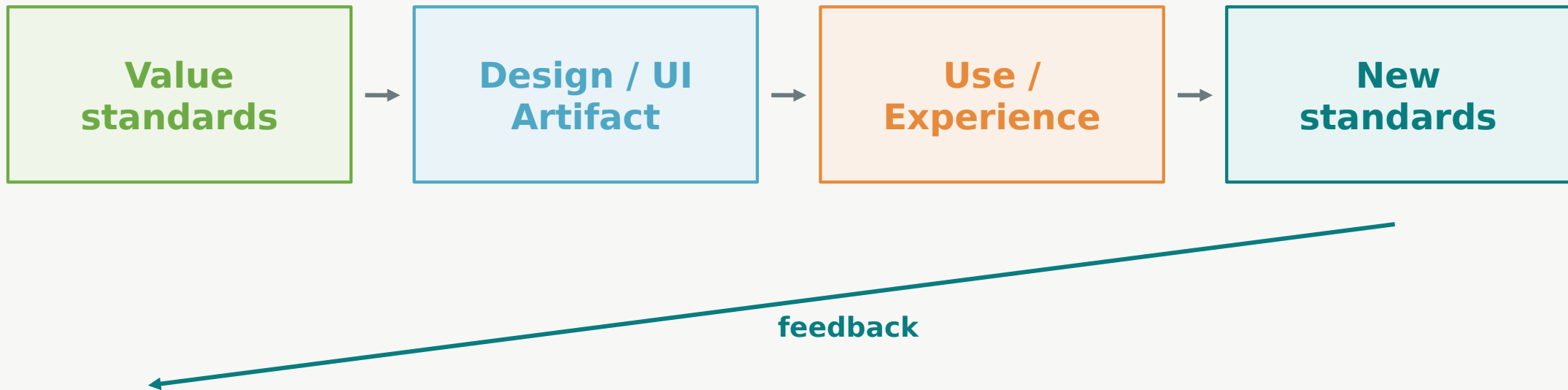


$$\mathbf{V_0 \rightarrow T_1 \rightarrow V_1 \rightarrow T_2 \rightarrow V_2 \rightarrow \dots}$$

Inquiry is recursive: standards shape inquiry; successful inquiry can reshape standards.

Artifact loop

Values become things; things train future values.

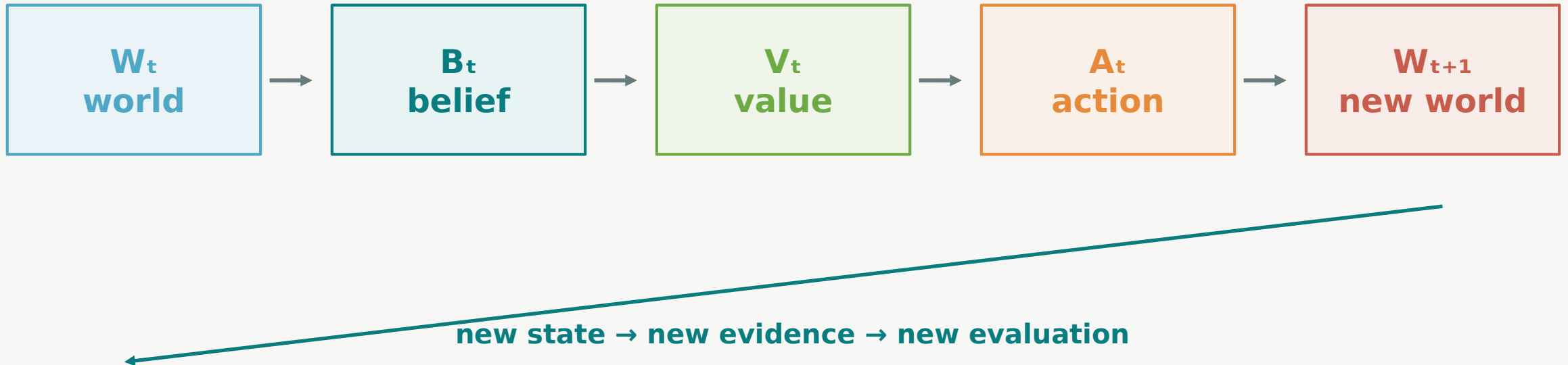


$$V_t \rightarrow A_t \rightarrow V_{t+1}$$

Aesthetic and practical values shape artifacts; living with artifacts reshapes taste and expectation.

World, belief, value, action

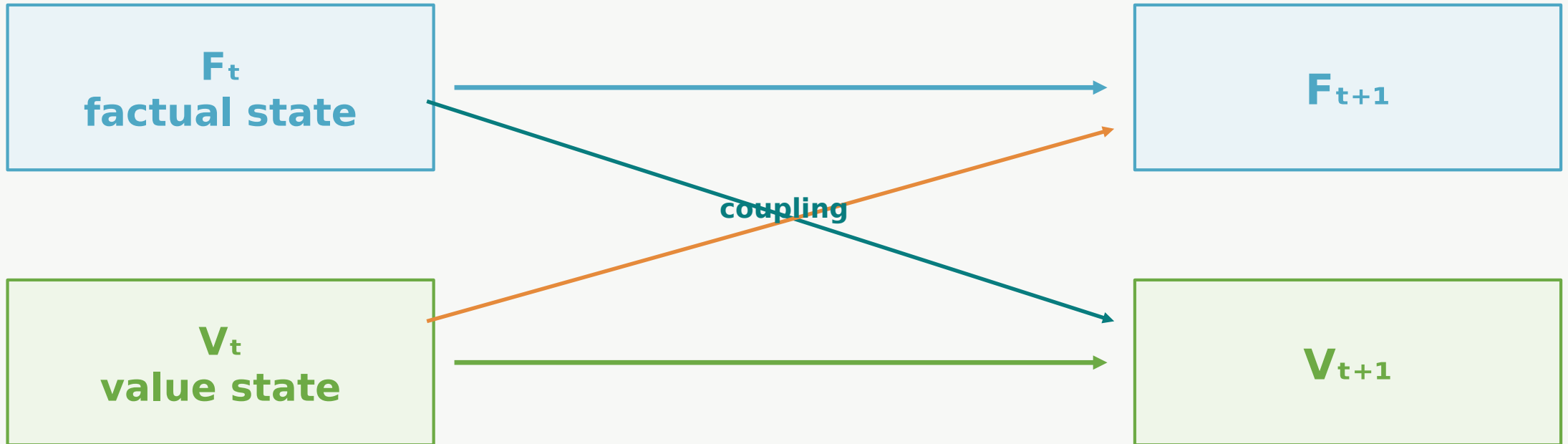
The agent-level feedback loop.



We do not merely observe state space. Evaluation helps determine which state we try to move into.

A coupled dynamical system

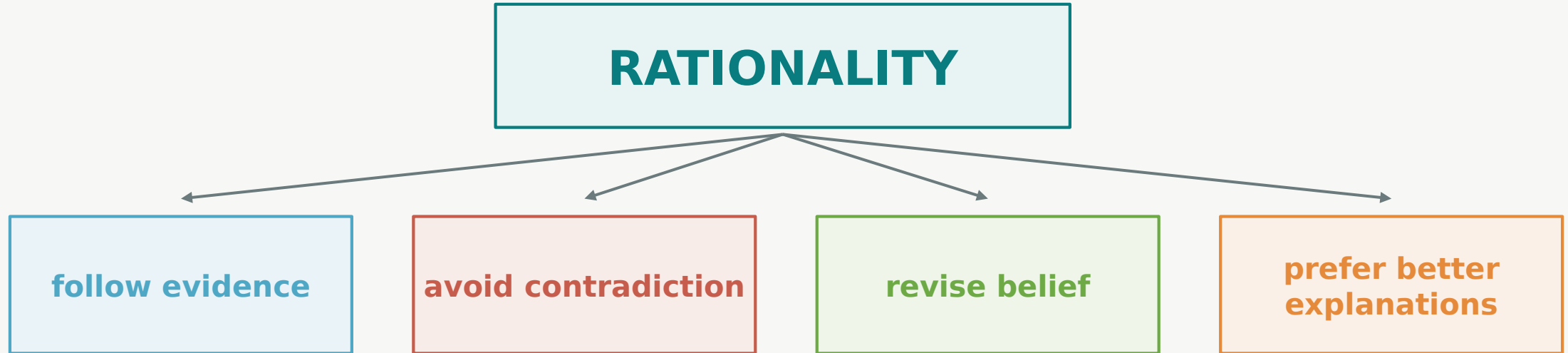
Not identical. Not independent.



$$(F_t, V_t) \mapsto (F_{t+1}, V_{t+1})$$

Rationality is already normative

The strongest “pure fact” refuge is not pure.



These are standards for how one ought to reason—not merely descriptions of what brains happen to do.

Remove every normative standard and “rationality” collapses into causal psychology.

Conclusion

Distinguishable does not mean cleanly separable.

$$F \neq V$$

$$F \perp V ?$$

$$(F_t, V_t) \rightarrow (F_{t+1}, V_{t+1})$$

1. Not identical
2. Not always separable
3. Often dynamically entangled

Putnam's point is not that facts are values. It is that our best descriptions and our best evaluations often cannot be cleanly pulled apart.